

What else to watch: *The Bicycle Thief* (1948, pp.94–95) ■ *Jalsaghar* (1958) ■ *The Cloud-Capped Star* (1960) ■ *Charulata* (1964) ■ *Ashani Sanket* (1973)



On the first day of shooting, Ray had no script, but Apu's story—based loosely on the novel by Bibhutibhushan Bandyopadhyay—was all in the director's head. He had already visualized it in a series of illustrations for the novel, which perhaps explains why so much of *Pather Panchali*'s beguiling power can be found in its imagery: white-hot light cutting swathes through the forest; the gathering clouds of the monsoon; water bugs twitching on a pond; a steam train glimpsed on the horizon.

Slow speed

Apu and his sister Durga (Uma Das Gupta) delight in running alongside the train, whose whistle vibrates along the wires of vast electricity pylons and can be heard long before the train itself appears. This is the fastest moving thing in Ray's tranquil movie.

"When I'm better," says Durga later on, as she lies dying of a fever,

Sarbojaya Ray (Karuna Banerjee) tends to her sick daughter Durga (Uma Das Gupta). She is helpless to stop a deadly fever.

"we'll go and look at the trains again." It's possible that Durga believes she will recover, and that Apu believes it too, but the audience knows there is really no hope. The camera paces queasily to and fro in the storm-wracked sickroom, following Apu's mother, Sarbojaya, as she watches her daughter slip away. It's a long, heartbreaking moment, and one that Apu will carry with him to the end of the movie and beyond, into two more movies about his life. ■

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Beautiful, sometimes funny, and full of love.

Pauline Kael

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Satyajit Ray Director

"Never before had one man had such a decisive impact on the films of his culture," wrote American film critic Roger Ebert, summing up Satyajit Ray's contribution to cinema in his review of the filmmaker's "Apu Trilogy." Before Ray, Indian movies were generally musicals, romances, and swashbucklers; after Apu, something of what it meant to be alive in India had been captured on film, and a new cultural tradition was born.

Ray founded Calcutta's first film society in 1947. He was working at an advertising agency when he directed his first feature, *Pather Panchali*, which won awards in France, London, and Venice. This and the two other Apu movies all strove for realism, but Ray later experimented with genre cinema, including fantasy and science fiction. His instinct for character, however, remained strong. He died at 70 in 1992.

Key movies

1955 *Pather Panchali*
1956 *Aparajito*
1959 *Apur Sansar*
1964 *Charulata*
1970 *Aranyer Din Ratri*